



10 Tips for Writing Clearly and Concisely

The basic rule for strong academic writing is to say everything relevant in as few words as possible. “Instant prose” can come from being forced to write papers of a particular length or being told that a paragraph must always contain exactly five sentences. This habit leads to the opposite of conciseness—wordiness in sentences and redundancy in paragraphs, which can confuse the reader and cloud your ideas.

Basically, clarity is about choosing the right words, whereas conciseness is making sure you don’t use too many.

First Steps:

- Read each paragraph aloud and locate the topic sentence. Be sure that all sentences support the topic sentence.
- Study sentences in your first draft to see what you can delete without losing meaning.

Replace Words and Phrases:

1. Delete weak intensifiers and qualifiers.
2. Delete redundant words and phrases.
3. Delete unnecessary “to be” verbs.
4. Change negative constructions into positive ones.
5. Follow “this”, “that”, “these”, or “those” with a noun.
6. Use specific nouns and phrases to be precise in meaning.

Revise Sentence Structure:

7. Keep your subjects and main verbs as close together as possible.
8. Watch for sentences and clauses beginning with “it is”, “this is”, or something similar.
9. Try to eliminate extra words wherever you can.
10. Replace wordy embedded questions with more specific noun or verb phrases.

Tips with Examples

Replace Words and Phrases:

1. Delete weak intensifiers and qualifiers; sentences are more forceful without them:

Wordy	Clear & Concise
We found the proposal <u>quite</u> feasible.	We found the proposal feasible.
The remark, though unkind, was <u>entirely</u> accurate.	The remark, though unkind, was accurate.
The scene was <u>extremely</u> typical.	The scene was typical.
That behavior is <u>fairly</u> unique for such an intelligent animal.	That behavior is unique for such an intelligent animal.

The first line <u>definitely</u> establishes that the father had been drinking.	The first line establishes that the father had been drinking.
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2. Delete redundant words and phrases:

Wordy	Change	Concise
<u>Any</u> student could <u>randomly</u> sit anywhere.	Delete “any” and “randomly”.	Students could sit <u>anywhere</u> . (If they could sit “anywhere,” seating was clearly “random.”)

3. Delete unnecessary “to be” verbs:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
The scene <u>is taking</u> place at night, in front of the capitol building.	“is taking place” -> “takes place” Fewer words, more direct	The scene <u>takes</u> place at night, in front of the capitol building.

Unnecessary “to be” verbs can clog up a sentence and be too indirect. Try to use verb phrases with only one word.

The friar <u>is knowledgeable</u> that Juliet is alive.	The friar <u>knows</u> that Juliet is alive.
<u>There are</u> two pine trees which <u>are growing</u> behind this house.	Two pine trees <u>grow</u> behind this house.

4. Change negative constructions into positive constructions:

Wordy	Clear & Concise
Housing for married students <u>is not unworthy</u> of consideration.	Housing for married students <u>is worthy</u> of consideration.

5. Follow “this”, “that”, “these”, or “those” with a noun, or replace it with a clearer phrase.

Wordy	Clear
This contributed to the lack of believability in the story.	This <u>duplicity</u> contributed to the lack of believability in the story.

6. Use specific nouns and phrases so that sentences are concrete in their conclusions instead of raising more questions:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
In both Orwell’s and Baldwin’s essays, <u>the feeling</u> of white supremacy <u>is very important</u> . (This raises the questions: How is it important? Why?)	“feeling” (vague) -> “consequences” (specific) “is very important” (vague) -> “trace the consequences” (specific)	Both Orwell and Baldwin <u>trace the consequences</u> of white supremacy. (This revision states its point conclusively.)

Revise Sentence Structure:

7. Keep your subject and main verb as close together as possible:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
In Johnson (2014), <u>the main purpose of the researcher's social experiment</u> that observed college students who take SOCI 600 <u>was to measure</u> their responses to certain stimuli.	More concise subject and main verb Rearrange the sentence so that the main verb follows the subject as closely as possible	<u>Researchers</u> in Johnson (2014) <u>measured</u> SOCI 600 students' responses to certain stimuli in a social experiment.

8. Watch for sentences or clauses that begin with "it is", "this is", or something similar; these can often be made more direct with strong subjects and verbs at the beginning:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
The Book of Ruth was probably written in the fifth century B.C. <u>It was</u> a time when women were considered the property of men.	Join the two sentences, delete "it is"	The Book of Ruth was probably written in the fifth century B.C., <u>when women</u> were considered the property of men.
<u>This is</u> a quote from Black Elk's autobiography <u>that</u> discloses his prophetic powers.	Reduce the relative clause "this is a quote... that discloses" -> "this quote... discloses"	<u>This quote</u> from Black Elk's autobiography <u>discloses</u> his prophetic powers.
<u>It is</u> frequently considered that <i>Hamlet</i> is Shakespeare's most puzzling play.	Make <i>Hamlet</i> the subject	<i>Hamlet</i> is frequently considered Shakespeare's most puzzling play.

9. Try to eliminate extra words, especially at the beginning of sentences, and use specific subjects, verbs, and objects:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
However, <u>it must be remembered that</u> Ruth's marriage <u>could have positive effects</u> on Naomi's situation.	Pare down wordy beginning Place "Ruth's marriage" directly at the beginning as a subject Use a more direct verb and a specific object	Ruth's marriage, however, <u>will provide security</u> for Naomi.
In high school, <u>where I had the opportunity for three years of working with the student government</u> , I realized how significantly a person's enthusiasm can be destroyed merely by <u>the attitudes of his superiors</u> .	Pare down wordy beginning to one prepositional phrase Use more specific phrases	In high school, <u>during three years on the student council</u> , I saw students' enthusiasm destroyed by <u>insecure teachers and cynical administrators</u> .
The economic situation of Anne Moody <u>was</u> also a crucial factor in the formation of her character.	Use specific nouns and verbs	Anne Moody's <u>poverty</u> also <u>helped form</u> her character.

Frequently, a chapter in a book reveals to the reader the main point that the author desires to bring out during the course of the chapter.	Simplify, simplify, simplify	A chapter's title often reveals its thesis.
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10. Replace embedded questions with clearer noun or verb phrases:

Wordy	Change	Clear & Concise
HIV-AIDS education should be focused on sexual education, but the actual facts about <u>what the disease is</u> and <u>how it affects people</u> are just as important.	Embedded question to noun phrase	HIV-AIDS education should be focused on sexual education, but the actual facts about <u>the disease</u> and <u>its effects</u> are just as important.
The extent of the conversation <u>is what drives the plot.</u>	Embedded question to verb phrase	The extent of the conversation <u>drives the plot.</u>

Adapted from Barnet, Sylvan and Marcia Stubbs. *Barnett and Stubbs Practical Guide to Writing*. Boston and Toronto: Little, Brown and Company, 1980.
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